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Published by

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Estimated reading time

5 min

Added on

2026-01-04

Address

<https://www.theguardian.com/sport/2026/jan/04/jacob-bethells-place-still-a-puzzle-as-gifted-batter-is-let-down-by-englands-planning>

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One down. Devilish gamble on Aussie plonk (5, 7)

Would Douglas Jardine have cheated at the crossword? No he would not. Or rather he would, but only in a way that still technically complied with the current rules of crosswords, while also causing a violent crossword-based diplomatic incident. Would Mike Brearley cheat at crosswords? No. He would instead ask the crossword why it feels it needs to be so difficult.

There has been a search for a defining Brendon McCullum image on this haphazard Ashes tour: a need-to-look-at-the-data moment, a McClaren's broly. If anything [we overprepared after the defeat in Brisbane](#) was good, and also dangerous because it made him look foolish, and the moment McCullum's insouciance looks foolish the whole thing is in danger of collapsing.

On a rain-shortened [first day of the fifth Ashes Test](#) we got the crossword. England's head coach is often seen doing crosswords during play. Here he was spotted flipping to the answers at the back of his book and then seeming to fill in a couple of unsolved clues. The clip was recycled gleefully across social media. It just seemed to fit with a man often accused of looking for shortcuts, skimping on his homework and so on.

There was even a degree of frustration here in an unbroken partnership of 154 between Joe Root and Harry Brook, enough to leave England in a belated position of strength in the final dead rubber of a losing series.

Root looked beautifully in control on a good, even pitch. Brook played half the time like a man desperately in need of the toilet, the rest like some kind of hyper-skilled alien princeling. But perhaps the most tantalising unsolved riddle on day one was the sight of Jacob Bethell out there batting at No 3 on the perfect stage, a lovely sunlit lime green oval, an elite Test attack, the event-glamour of the New Year Test.

In the event Bethell produced a perfect miniature of his time around the Test team so far, all easy lines, symmetry, balance, shadow brilliance, and always leaving you wanting more. He is obviously a genuine high-end talent. But does anyone actually know what to do with this? Do we trust these people not to break him?

Bethell came out to bat here at 35 for one after Ben Duckett had breezed his way to a fun and flighty 27, opening the innings with all the hard, seasoned permanence of Paddington Bear having an accident with a bar of soap and a skateboard. Bethell faced the final ball of Mitchell Starc's fourth over. He curtain-railed his bat inside the line, sleeves rolled, all springy, coiled intent.

And as ever he looked great. He left, he nudged, he defended in tight shapes. He ticked along to nought off nine balls. Bethell has no trigger movements. He just stands still and plays from the crease, a tribute to the speed of his hands and the fast-twitch energy in his feet. Scott Boland ripped one past his outside edge, a good, cinematic play and miss. Nought off 11. Then it was nought off 13 as Starc whizzed a really horrible bouncer across his nose.

Ball 15 was shorter, and beautifully crunched through point to break the spell. At which point you couldn't help thinking, hmm, maybe they have solved this. Maybe they can game Test batting. Maybe the clue was there in the back of the book all along.

The answer to this will take a little decoding. And it will require some care from here. Bethell did a very interesting interview with Nasser Hussain on a Sky podcast released just before this Test. He sounded smart, confident and single-minded in the way of all elite sports people. But he also said some odd things.

Had he read, Nasser asked, Greg Chappell's recent article suggesting Test batters needed to defend better? No, he hadn't. But, yeah, Bethell supposed, you could defend more. But you won't score many runs that way.

Chappell scored 7,000 of them. Bethell has yet to get to 20 in the first innings of a Test. Hmm. Does he think young players should start at No 3 or work their way up? No, no working up, his game is perfectly adjusted to batting three. Which may be true. But how does he know this? How does he know it with such certainty? Bethell has never scored a first-class hundred.

Later he said he never listened to any outside advice or suggestions ("noise"). Really? Why not? And is it helpful that the only voices Bethell hears are those of his captain and coach, who both favour positive reinforcement, the you-go-girl style of preparation? Doubt Kills More Dreams Than Failure Ever Will. This is McCullum's X account strapline. Maybe that's true too. But doubt can also be a useful tool.

Bethell was out here caught behind edging a fine ball from Boland, although even this was a good edge, an edge that flew, that looked right. Would a No 3 who had played No 3 for a year, who was utterly plugged into that role, have been able to leave it?

We will never know, or at least not for now, because Bethel is one of the areas where Bazball (as was) has blinked in the past 12 months. They really should have trusted the initial impression in New Zealand, should have had him in all year in that slot.

How would Bethell look now if he'd played all summer, then started in Perth, as opposed to being starved of cricket after sitting on the bench at the Indian Premier League (and please, spare us the standard learned-so-much stuff)? Like everything else in this cramped and complex sport, this is a question wrapped up in guesswork and cryptic clues. Although as ever, and just as at is to one down above – *Jacob's Creek; bet hell* – the answer for England is still likely to be Jacob Bethell.

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